

Homepage Discovery Map — what we achieved, what we have not, and the constraints

This note is for the client. It is an honest status against *Destination Discovery Map — Client Requirements*.

How to read it

- **Achieved, with a constraint** — the behaviour is in the prototype, but it is incomplete, approximated, or limited by Google Maps / this being a frontend demo.
- **Not achieved** — either we have not built it yet, or Google Maps **cannot** honour the brief without changing the requirement.

This is a **working prototype**, not the production homepage. Catalog, ranking, and copy are local sample data. There is no live booking, CMS, or crawlable destination site yet.

Related brief: [client-requirements.md](#).

What this prototype is

A four-level recommendation funnel on **Google Maps**:

World (countries) → Country (cities) → City (attractions) → Attraction (products)

Preference chips re-rank pins and the list. Trade-offs and match labels sit next to recommendations. A results panel sits under the map.

It is **not** yet the RosoTravel-owned canvas the brief describes (Natural Earth world, no third-party branding, quiet city diagram, globe in the same visual language). Those items need a custom map surface, not Google.

Achieved — with constraints

These items exist in the prototype. Each has a limit you should know before treating it as signed-off.

Funnel, preference, and honesty

Brief item	What we did	Constraint
Four-level funnel (L0–L3)	Pin tap and list tap descend one level. Breadcrumbs and zoom controls climb.	Native Google pinch/scroll can still pan and zoom the <i>basemap</i> without changing funnel level. Level changes are driven by our chrome and pins, not by Google’s zoom.
A pin is a recommendation	Only catalogued destinations / cities / attractions get pins.	Sample catalog only (6 countries). Not live inventory.

Brief item	What we did	Constraint
We reorder, we never hide	Every destination stays on the map; match label and copy change with the chip.	City pins are ranked by “default base + pick count”, not by preference-specific city copy. City rows reuse country why/chips.
One entity type per level	World = countries, country = cities, city = attractions. Products stay in the panel.	Attraction pins show a product count badge. Strict reading of “products never appear on the map” would drop that number.
Preference row — one tap re-ranks	Chips re-rank pins, rewrite labels/copy, reorder the list, update the count line.	Re-tint of recommended countries is an overlay on Google land, not a restyle of Google’s own polygons. Unreliable if Google labels/roads show through (see Map ID note below).
Poor fit returns to World	If the open country is “worth considering” (tier 3) for the new chip, we leave that view.	Uses country tier only. A city or attraction that is a poor fit does not, by itself, bounce the view.
Preference is never a URL	Chip is session state. URL does not change.	List hrefs look like /destinations/... but clicks are intercepted — those pages do not exist . Indexable routing is not built.
Transition flash states what changed	Lines such as “Poland · 5 cities prioritised”, “Re-ranked for culture & history”.	There is no poster or skeleton behind first paint. Google tiles can still visibly load.
Pan never changes level	Dragging does not open a country or city.	Google still pans a wayfinding map. The brief’s “not a Google Maps-style wayfinding tool” is not met by the surface itself.

Map levels (look and data)

Brief item	What we did	Constraint
L0 — country pins, pick counts, match-tier pills	White pills, coloured tier, country name, pick badge.	Not Natural Earth. Google is Web Mercator only. World frame is a fitted camera, not a Natural Earth card. Pins can still collide; we do not move labels on both axes.
L0 — warm land, pale water, hairline borders, no roads/labels	JSON styles hide roads, POIs, and labels; country overlay tints recommended land.	A Cloud Map ID (required for Advanced Markers) ignores JSON styles. Overlay still paints, but Google’s roads/labels can return. Google attribution cannot be removed (terms of use).

Brief item	What we did	Constraint
L1 — Mercator fitted to the country	Google is already Mercator; we fly to country bounds; selected country is filled darker.	Neighbours are Google's world, not an unlabelled custom basemap. Attraction clusters are not built . City count is always capped at 8 — we do not drop pins for 390px readability.
L1 crowding rules (drop badge → drop label → keep in list only)	Not implemented. All city pins keep name + count.	To achieve this we need our own collision layout (or accept Google's marker collision, which hides pins — the brief says never drop from the product, only from the map surface).
L2 — dotted field, centre, km rings, scale, true coordinates	Centre dot, concentric rings, Google scale control, attractions at real lat/lng.	Surface is still Google's map , not a quiet dotted diagram. Roads/imagery can remain. Rings are an overlay, not the specified city treatment.
L3 — stay at city scale; selected attraction emphasised; siblings tappable	Camera stays on the city; selected pill is emphasised; other attractions stay tappable.	Sibling "quieter treatment" is a quieter pill, not a full visual spec. 3D markers may hide behind Google's collision behaviour.
Commercial detail arrives late	World/country: counts only. City: rating, reviews, from-price. Attraction: duration, exact price, CTA.	Numbers are hardcoded sample data , not live prices or availability.
Caps 8 / 4 / 3	Code slices cities to 8, attractions to 4, unique products to 3.	"Readability outranks the ceiling" is not implemented. We always show the cap when the catalog has that many, even if labels crowd.
Product cards (why, trade-off, review block, priced CTA)	Layout is in the panel.	Review block copy is static — the same quote is labelled for the active preference; it is not a real preference-filtered review slice. Check dates is a button with no booking action.
Empty photography	Dashed photo slots. No stock, no AI images.	Real photography has not landed. Drop slots only.

Product principles that are only partly true

Brief item	What we did	Constraint
Map is enhancement; list is the content	A ranked list sits under the map and mirrors pin order.	List is client-rendered in this Vite app. It is not server-rendered, not crawlable, and not a fallback if the map fails. Links do not resolve.

Brief item	What we did	Constraint
Unified homepage block with Travel Preferences and How We Do It	Preference row sits with the map.	How We Do It is not in this prototype. The map is a standalone page, not a homepage section at ~200px on a 390px screen. Current map height is ~220–360px (flat) and taller in 3D.
Touch 44px	Preference chips, list rows, breadcrumbs, and CTA use 44px-class hit areas.	Map pins are visually small; we have not implemented “tap within 22px resolves to nearest pin”. Google hit-testing is on the marker only.
Contrast 4.5:1; never fade text	De-emphasis uses fill/border on pills, not faded type.	Not audited. We have not measured 4.5:1 on match labels and smallest metadata.
Ranking by decision value / review volume in category	Attractions sort by match tier, then review count.	Not “review volume within category ” as specified. City ranking is not preference-driven. Copy is editorial sample, not assembled from verified live product facts.

Phase 2 — 3D

Brief item	What we did	Constraint
3D globe with rotation/tilt	A toggle switches to Google photorealistic 3D (or tilted hybrid if 3D fails).	This is Google’s 3D tiles , not a RosoTravel globe in the same language as the flat map. Needs extra Google APIs and billing. Country tints and city rings do not appear on the 3D surface.

Not achieved

Split into two kinds: **blocked by Google Maps** (cannot ship the brief on this engine), and **not built yet** (can ship on a custom surface + production site).

Cannot achieve on Google Maps (without changing the brief)

These are limits of the Maps JavaScript API and Google’s terms, not missing coding time.

Brief requirement	Why it is not achievable here
Phase 1: Natural Earth projection	Google Maps is Web Mercator only. There is no Natural Earth (or other cartographic) projection.
Own vector geometry , RosoTravel styling, no third-party branding	The basemap is Google’s. Attribution (logo and data credits) must stay visible . Hiding it breaks Google’s terms.
No provider labels, city names, or roads on the surface	We can hide many of them with styles, but a Map ID fights JSON styles, and Google’s world remains underneath. This is

Brief requirement	Why it is not achievable here
	a skin, not our canvas.
Recommended countries re-tinted as part of the basemap	Overlay polygons can approximate this. They are not Google's land, and they will not match the brief's "own geometry".
L2 as a quiet dotted field (diagram, not a street map)	Google city view is still a map (roadmap, satellite, or hybrid). Overlays do not turn it into the specified diagram.
Phase 2: globe in the same visual language as the flat map	Google 3D is photorealistic tiles — a different product (heavy, branded, not our land tints).
" Not a Google Maps-style wayfinding tool" as the homepage centrepiece	Using Google as the surface keeps wayfinding in the centre of the homepage, even with chrome hidden.

What it would take: a custom map (for example d3-geo + Natural Earth for Phase 1, orthographic globe for Phase 2). That is a **different engine**, not a settings change on Google Maps.

Not built yet (product / platform)

These can be achieved. They need production work, not a Google feature flag.

Brief requirement	What is missing	What it takes
Server-rendered, crawlable list and real /destinations/... pages	Dummy hrefs ; clicks stay in the map. No SSR.	Real site (e.g. Next.js), default ranking in HTML, preference still session-only.
Map error / no-map fallback	If Google fails, there is no designed degrade to the list.	List as the section; map optional. No error modal on the map.
Poster / first paint	Map can block or flash empty while tiles load.	Static poster; hydrate map behind it.
Loading-level skeleton	Not implemented.	Brief skeleton matching the target level; flash line still immediate.
How We Do It + homepage section height	Standalone demo page; map taller than ~200px.	Compose as one homepage block; lock section height so descending a level does not lengthen the page.
L1 attraction clusters	Country view shows cities only.	Cluster marks with pick counts, no prices.
Pin collision (move, never drop; then badge → label → list-only)	Pins may overlap.	Custom layout at 390px; Google's hide-on-collision is the wrong rule.

Brief requirement	What is missing	What it takes
Readability cap (show fewer than 8/4 if labels crowd)	Always show the numeric cap.	Measure label overlap; hold extras in the list.
City-specific fit copy and ranking	Cities inherit country copy; city order is default base + picks.	Per-city fits (or equivalent) by preference.
Reason chips from verified product facts	Editorial strings in the sample catalog.	Generate chips from live product fields; they must not contradict L3.
Preference-specific review slices	Same quote, relabelled.	Real review query per audience + "why these reviews" snippet.
Working Check dates CTA	Button only.	Hook to booking / availability.
Contrast audit	Not measured.	4.5:1 on all functional text.
Nearest-pin hit testing (22px)	Marker-only hits.	Custom hit target around small pins.
Live catalog / CMS / API	All data in the frontend sample file.	Homepage-slice bootstrap (load once — see HOME PAGE_MAP_DATA_LOADING.md).
Real photography	Empty slots only.	Product photography; still no stock/AI.

One-page scorecard

	Status
Recommendation funnel (4 levels, preference chips, trade-offs, match labels)	Achieved in the prototype, on sample data
Spec map (Natural Earth, no Google branding, quiet city diagram, matching globe)	Not achieved — Google Maps cannot deliver this
Production homepage (SSR list, real pages, poster, fallback, live prices, booking CTA)	Not achieved — not this prototype's job; needs the real site
Google flat + photorealistic 3D with our pins	Achieved , as a comparison surface, with Google's constraints

What we recommend saying

This prototype proves the **recommendation funnel**: preference, four levels, honest labels, and a list beside the map. It does **not** prove the **specified map surface**. Google Maps cannot be Natural Earth, cannot drop Google branding, and cannot become the quiet city diagram or RosoTravel globe in the brief. Those need a custom canvas. Everything else still open — crawlable pages,

photography, live prices, Check dates, clusters, pin collision, first-paint poster — is production work on top of that canvas, not a Google setting.

If the decision is to **keep Google Maps** as the shipped surface, the brief's Phase 1 (Natural Earth), basemap non-negotiable (no third-party branding), L2 diagram, and Phase 2 globe **must be rewritten**. We cannot "finish" those items on this engine.

If the decision is to **keep the brief**, Google Maps stays a useful comparison, not the homepage.